

# UNDERSTANDING THE BRITISH CONSTITUTION

A constitution is a set of principles by which country is governed. It includes all of the institutions that are responsible for running country and how their powers are kept in check.

The constitution also includes laws and conventions



## HOUSE OF COMMONS

The House of Commons is regarded as the most important of the two chambers in Parliament because its members are democratically elected.

Each Member of Parliament (MP) represents a parliamentary constituency, which is a small area of the country. MPs have a number of responsibilities, including:

- Representing everyone in their constituency
- Helping to create new laws



## HOUSE OF LORDS

Members of the House of Lords, known as peers, are not elected by the people and do not represent a constituency.

The House of Lords is normally more independent of the government than the House of Commons. It can suggest amendments or propose new laws, which are then discussed by MPs.

The House of Lords checks laws that have been passed by the House of Commons to ensure they are fit for purpose. It also holds the government to account to make sure that it is working in the best interests of the people.



## THE MONARCHY

The UK has a constitutional monarchy. This means that the King or Queen does not rule the country, but appoints the government that the people have chosen in a democratic election.

All Acts of Parliament are made in the monarch's name.



## THE GOVERNMENT

The system of government in the UK is a parliamentary democracy.

Voters in constituencies elect members of parliament in a General Election. The party with the majority of Members of Parliament (MPs) forms the government.

The Prime Minister (PM) is the leader of the political party in power.

The PM appoints about 20 senior MPs to become ministers in charge of departments, including:

- Chancellor of the Exchequer – responsible for the economy and;
- Home Secretary – responsible for crime, policing, and immigration



## THE JUDICIARY

Judges (who are together called 'the judiciary') are responsible for interpreting the law and ensuring that trials are conducted fairly.

Sometimes the actions of the government are claimed to be illegal. If the judges agree, then the government must either change its policies or ask Parliament to change the law.



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